

Paper 2 Comprehension — Sections B & C

Working Notes on Question-Handling Techniques

These notes teach you how to answer every question type that appears in Sections B and C of Paper 2 (45 of the 50 marks; the Summary is treated separately in Doc 31 and Doc 32).

Every question in Sections B and C falls into one of two categories.

Category A — Locate and Paraphrase. The answer is in the text. Your job is to find it and reword it. Mechanical, not creative.

Category B — Inference Based. The text gives you no line to lift. You must reason from clues. Interpretive, not mechanical.

If you cannot tell which category a question belongs to, ask yourself one thing: *is the answer already in the passage, or do I have to work it out?* If the answer is there, it is Cat A. If you have to reason your way to it, it is Cat B.

Universal rules for both categories

1. Read the passage twice. Once for plot, once paragraph-by-paragraph as you answer.
2. Check the mark allocation. One mark = one point. Two marks = two distinct points. Never give fewer than the marks demand.
3. Check the answer-line allocation. It tells you how long the answer should be.
4. Quote sparingly. Quote only when the question demands a quotation, or when you need to anchor an inference to specific evidence.
5. When you quote, use inverted commas and copy accurately.
6. Never lump two points into one sentence. The marker must be able to see your points separately.

NOTE: The two-category framework here is A-Worthy's own pedagogical grouping. SEAB does not officially divide Paper 2 questions this way — but this division reflects the actual cognitive demand of each question type and makes revision tractable.

Three Mnemonics That Carry You Through Every Question

You only need to remember three short mnemonics for the whole of Sections B and C: **SWIFT**, **FLIP**, and **EIL**. Each does a different job. Together they replace the need to memorise sixteen separate procedures.

SWIFT — the category-identifier. Use this in the first ten seconds after reading any question. Does the question contain any of these signal words?

- **S** — **S**uggest (“what does this suggest”)
- **W** — **W**hy (“why do you think”)
- **I** — **I**mpression (“what impression”, “what sort of person”)
- **F** — **F**eeling (“state of mind”, “reaction”, “how did X feel”)
- **T** — **T**one (“tone”, “attitude”)

If **any** SWIFT word appears → this is a **Cat B (Inference)** question.

If **no** SWIFT word appears → this is a **Cat A (Locate-and-Paraphrase)** question.

FLIP — the Cat A move-sequence. Every Cat A question is solved by the same four moves.

- **F** — **F**ind the relevant lines in the named paragraph.
- **L** — **L**ift the exact words you need (use inverted commas if you are quoting).
- **I** — **I**nterpret what they mean in plain English.
- **P** — **P**araphrase into your own words *if* the question demands it (*e.g.* “*in your own words*”); otherwise keep the lift clean.

EIL — the Cat B move-sequence. Every Cat B question is solved by the same three moves.

- **E** — **Evidence**: name the specific words, phrase, or action in the text.
- **I** — **Implication**: state what those words suggest.
- **L** — **Link**: tie the implication back to the question.

How the three fit together in one sweep: read the question → apply **SWIFT** to decide category → apply **FLIP** or **EIL** to build the answer. The question-type-specific techniques below are refinements of FLIP and EIL — they are not replacements for them.

NOTE: EIL is the A-Worthy inference scaffold first introduced in Doc 26. FLIP and SWIFT are introduced here for the first time.

Category A — Locate and Paraphrase

What unites Cat A questions: the answer exists in the passage. Your task is locating the correct lines and (often) rewording them so the marker sees you understood what you read, not just that you can copy. Eight distinct question types fall under Cat A.

A1 — Direct Detail Retrieval

Technique. Find the specific detail, fact, or feature stated in the passage and write it down. Lifting is permitted.

Why this technique works. The examiner has placed a literal fact in the text. The mark is for showing you can locate it accurately, not for paraphrasing it. Rewording risks distorting the meaning and losing the mark. Lift cleanly and stop.

1. Identify the keyword in the question (*e.g.* “feature”, “thing”, “reason stated”).
2. Scan the named paragraph for the matching detail.
3. Lift the exact phrase or sentence. Use inverted commas.
4. Stop. Do not add commentary.
5. Watch the Excess Denied rule: if you give one wrong detail alongside a correct one, the mark is cancelled.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The detail / feature is _____.” (Lift the exact words; one clean sentence; no commentary.)

Worked Example A1 — Specimen Paper Q16(b)

Question: Paragraph 2 says T. rex ‘had at least one leg on the ground’. Which detail from the film is incorrect based on this characteristic of T. rex? [1]

Answer: The detail showing the T. rex running fast enough to chase a speeding jeep is incorrect, because a real T. rex — always keeping at least one leg on the ground — could not have reached such a speed.

Why this scores: The answer locates the specific film detail (chasing a jeep), then links it back to the stated biological characteristic.

A2 — Targeted Quotation Extraction

Technique. The question names a precise quantity (one word, two words, a phrase, a sentence). Lift exactly that quantity — no more, no less. Use inverted commas.

Why this technique works. Quotation questions test reading precision. The examiner wants to see whether you can identify the single most relevant unit of language. Giving one extra word, or copying inaccurately, fails the test even if your understanding is correct.

1. Identify the unit the question demands: word / phrase / sentence / a fixed word-count.
2. Re-read the named paragraph. Underline candidate units.
3. Choose the candidate whose meaning matches the descriptor in the question most tightly.
4. Copy it character-for-character. Use inverted commas.
5. If a sentence is asked for, copy from the capital letter to the closing punctuation mark.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“_____.” (Just the quoted unit, in inverted commas. No introduction. No explanation unless the question asks for one.)

Worked Example A2 — Specimen Paper Q9(a)

Question: Identify one word in Paragraph 4 which suggests that Coach is surprised that the writer wants to continue swimming. [1]

Answer: “incredulous”.

Why this scores: It is one word (the question asked for one), it is in inverted commas, and it conveys disbelief — the precise shade of meaning the question demanded.

A3 — Own-Words Paraphrase

Technique. The question contains the phrase “in your own words”. Identify the key words in the passage, then substitute them with synonyms of equivalent meaning and register. Do not lengthen the sentence.

Why this technique works. This is a vocabulary test disguised as a comprehension question. The examiner is checking whether you actually understand the words — not just recognise them. Lifting the words back is automatic zero. Substituting too loosely (*e.g.* “hatred” → “dislike”) shifts the meaning and loses the mark.

1. Locate the sentence in the text that answers the question.
2. Circle the content words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs).
3. Find a synonym for each content word that preserves the same intensity and connotation.
4. Rewrite the sentence using your synonyms.
5. Check: have you altered the meaning? If yes, retry.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The writer believes / means that _____, because _____.” (Replace the content words from the text with synonyms; preserve meaning and register.)

Worked Example A3 — Specimen Paper Q8

Question: Referring to Paragraph 3, explain in your own words what the writer thinks is unfair about the way Coach organises calisthenics. [2]

Answer: The writer believes Coach treats the older swimmers more harshly: while the younger children are dismissed early, the senior swimmers are made to perform an exhausting series of strength exercises despite already having completed a long training session.

Why this scores: Two points are given (younger children dismissed early; older swimmers forced into additional exhausting exercises) — one mark each. Original words such as “calisthenics” and “dismissed” have been replaced (“strength exercises”; “sent away”).

NOTE: Word-for-word substitution is safer than re-engineering the whole sentence. Aim to change one or two words per content point, no more.

A4 — Multi-Evidence Justification

Technique. The question gives you a claim from the text and asks for two or three pieces of evidence supporting it. Find each distinct piece, quote it, and briefly link it to the claim.

Why this technique works. The marks scale with the number of evidence pieces (often 2 or 3

marks). Each piece must be *distinct* — the marker is checking whether you can find separate supporting details, not whether you can rephrase the same point twice. The brief link confirms your understanding.

1. Underline the claim in the question (e.g. “the best workout ever”).
2. Scan only the named paragraph.
3. Identify three (or however many) genuinely different details that support the claim.
4. For each, write: quotation + a short link (“which shows / which suggests”).
5. Check distinctness: do any two of your points say the same thing? If yes, replace one.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“Firstly, ‘_____’, which shows / suggests that _____. Secondly, ‘_____’, which shows / suggests that _____. Thirdly, ...” (One quotation + one link per mark. Repeat as many times as the marks demand.)

Worked Example A4 — Specimen Paper Q13

Question: The writer claimed she had had “the best workout ever”. Explain how this claim is supported with reference to three pieces of evidence from Paragraph 6. [3]

Answer:

1. She describes the cold as “invigorating”, showing that the storm energised rather than exhausted her.
2. She reports feeling “stronger than ever”, showing that the workout had built her physical capacity.
3. She refers to “the deepest sleep” she had after the swim, showing that her body had been fully exerted.

Why this scores: Three distinct quotations, each followed by a one-clause link to the claim. No two points overlap.

A5 — Cartoon-Head Position Support

Technique. Two characters (drawn as cartoon heads) hold opposing views. You are asked to find evidence in the passage supporting one or both views. Lift evidence, then explain in your own words how it supports the view.

Why this technique works. This question type tests two skills at once: locating relevant material (Cat A) and demonstrating you understand *why* that material supports the stated position. Evidence alone is half the mark; the link to the position is the other half.

1. Read each character’s stated view carefully. Underline the key idea.
2. Go to the paragraph specified in the question.
3. Find a detail that directly supports the view.
4. Quote or paraphrase the detail.
5. Add a short clause explaining how the detail supports the view.
6. If two pieces are required, ensure they are genuinely distinct.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The text states that _____, which supports [Character]’s view because _____.” (One evidence + one explicit link to the character’s position. Repeat for each required piece.)

Worked Example A5 — Specimen Paper Q19(b)

Question: Give one piece of evidence from Paragraph 2 to support John’s view that “the filmmakers deliberately chose not to tell the truth about dinosaurs”. [1]

Answer: Paragraph 2 states that the real Dilophosaurus did not spit venom, yet the filmmakers chose to show it spitting venom in the film. This deliberate alteration of a known scientific fact shows the filmmakers consciously departed from the truth.

Why this scores: The evidence is specific (Dilophosaurus venom-spitting), it is from the correct paragraph, and the explanatory clause makes the connection to John’s view explicit.

A6 — Contrast Identification

Technique. The question asks you to identify the contrast between two ideas, places, or states. Locate both halves of the contrast and state each clearly, in opposition.

Why this technique works. A contrast question is incomplete without both sides. Marks are awarded for showing that you can articulate the two ends of the opposition — not just describe one side. “What” questions ask for the contrast itself; “how” questions ask how the contrast is created (which is a Cat B language-use question).

1. Identify the two things being contrasted in the question.
2. Find the line(s) describing the first.
3. Find the line(s) describing the second.
4. State each side in your own words, using clearly opposing language (*e.g.* “calm” vs “chaotic”).
5. Make sure both sides are present in your answer.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“Whereas [the first thing] is _____, [the second thing] is _____.” (Both halves must appear. Use opposing adjectives.)

Worked Example A6 — past-year style

Question: In Paragraph 8, what is the contrast between the atmosphere inside the library and outside in the street?

Answer: Inside the library, the atmosphere was hushed and orderly, with readers absorbed in silent study. Outside in the street, the atmosphere was loud and chaotic, with the noise of traffic and the press of the crowd.

Why this scores: Both halves of the contrast are stated, and the opposing pair (hushed/loud; orderly/chaotic) makes the contrast unmistakable.

A7 — Flow-Chart Role Mapping

Technique. The question provides a flow chart with paragraphs on the left and a box of candidate phrases. Match the phrase that best summarises the dominant action, role, or feeling per paragraph.

Why this technique works. The candidate phrases are deliberately close in meaning. The mark is for picking the *most precise* match. To do this you must (a) understand the paragraph as a whole and (b) understand the shade of meaning of each candidate phrase. Distractor phrases match only part of the paragraph, or describe the wrong character.

1. Re-read each specified paragraph. Note the main action or role of the named character.
2. Read every phrase in the box. Eliminate ones that are clearly wrong.
3. For each paragraph, narrow to two candidate phrases.
4. Pick the phrase whose meaning matches the dominant role most precisely.
5. Check: does each phrase appear in the chart only once? If two paragraphs share a phrase, you have made an error.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

(Write only the matched phrase from the box, copied exactly.)

No prose. No explanation. The flow chart is a matching task; full sentences are not required.

Worked Example A7 — Specimen Paper Q14

Question: Match the role to each paragraph stage.

Answer:

- Paragraphs 1–2: **questioning authority** (the writer challenges Coach’s instruction).
- Paragraphs 3–4: **considering an independent course of action** (she decides to stay and swim alone).
- Paragraph 5: **embracing a physical challenge** (she swims through the storm).

- Paragraph 6: **gaining a vision of new possibilities** (the experience opens her future as a long-distance swimmer).

Why this scores: Each chosen phrase captures the paragraph’s dominant action. Distractors (“being an observer”, “negotiating a compromise”) describe partial or wrong actions.

A8 — Reason / Justification Question

Technique. The question asks “why” something is the case, or asks how a stated claim could be justified. The reason is given in the passage; find it and rephrase it.

Why this technique works. Justification questions are literal at heart — the cause is in the text. The mark is for locating the cause and stating it in clear English. Vague or generic reasons (“because of science”) score nothing; specific ones (“because soft tissue does not fossilise”) score.

1. Underline the claim or fact in the question that needs justification.
2. Find the sentence in the passage that gives the reason.
3. Rephrase the reason in your own words.
4. Check: is the reason specific enough to identify which fact in the text you are pointing to?

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“This is because _____, which means that _____.” (State the specific cause from the text, then briefly explain its consequence.)

Worked Example A8 — Specimen Paper Q15

Question: The writer says the dinosaurs are “far from scientifically accurate”. With reference to Paragraph 1, how could the filmmakers justify this? [1]

Answer: The filmmakers could argue that the film was made for entertainment, not as a scientific record, and that depicting dinosaurs in a more dramatic form was necessary to engage cinema audiences.

Why this scores: The reason is specific (entertainment purpose; dramatic effect for audiences), drawn from Paragraph 1, and stated in the student’s own phrasing.

Category B — Inference Based

What unites Cat B questions: the answer is not in the passage. You must reason from clues. The text gives you evidence; your job is to work out what it implies. Eight distinct question types fall under Cat B.

The universal Cat B structure: EIL.

- **E** — Evidence: identify the specific words, phrases, or actions in the text.
- **I** — Implication: state what those words suggest.
- **L** — Link: tie the implication back to what the question asked.

Every Cat B question is some variation of this structure.

NOTE: EIL is A-Worthy’s inference template (formally introduced in Doc 26). It is the most reliable inference scaffold because it forces you to anchor every claim to textual evidence.

B1 — Basic Inference (“suggest” / “why do you think”)

Technique. The question contains “suggest”, “what do you think”, or “why do you think”. The answer is not stated; it must be reasoned. Look at the action or detail in the text, ask what it implies about feelings, motives, or circumstances, and state that implication clearly.

Why this technique works. Writers signal inference through behaviour rather than statement (*e.g.* “scurried” implies haste and fear; “closed the door silently” implies tension or guilt). Examiners reward students who can move from observed behaviour to underlying meaning. Lifting the action alone gets zero — the inference is the mark.

1. Identify the specific action, detail, or phrase the question points to.
2. Ask: what does this behaviour normally suggest about a person or situation?
3. State the underlying feeling, motive, or implication directly.
4. If marks > 1, add a second distinct implication or anchor to a second piece of evidence.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The [action / phrase / detail] of ‘_____’ suggests that _____, which shows that _____.” (Pure EIL: Evidence → Implication → Link.)

Worked Example B1 — Specimen Paper Q7

Question: The writer’s teammates “leaped out of the pool, scurried across the deck, grabbed towels”. What does this description suggest about how the teammates felt in this moment? [1]

Answer: The rapid, sequential verbs (“leaped”, “scurried”, “grabbed”) suggest that the teammates felt fearful and intimidated, and were anxious to escape Coach’s anger as quickly as possible.

Why this scores: Evidence (the three verbs) is named; the inference (fear, intimidation, urgency) follows directly; the link to the question (“how the teammates felt”) closes the answer.

B2 — Character Trait / Impression Inference

Technique. The question asks what impression you get of a character, or what kind of person they are. Give a one-word or short-phrase trait, and (if marks demand) anchor it to behaviour in the text.

Why this technique works. Character traits are inferred from action, speech, and reaction. The mark is for naming the trait precisely. “Nice” or “mean” is too vague; “compassionate”, “domineering”, “calculating” are precise enough to earn the mark.

1. Re-read the named paragraph(s). Note the character’s actions and speech.
2. Ask: what kind of person behaves this way?
3. Choose a precise adjective or short phrase from your character-trait vocabulary bank.
4. If 2+ marks, briefly anchor to the action that demonstrates the trait.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“[Character] comes across as _____ — her / his _____ shows that _____.” (Precise trait + anchor to specific action.)

Worked Example B2 — past-year style

Question: What impression do you get of Alma from Paragraph 5? [1]

Answer: Alma comes across as resolute and unyielding — her “emphatic tone” and refusal to be argued with show that, once she has decided on a course of action, she will not allow others to change her mind.

Why this scores: Two precise traits are given (resolute, unyielding) and both are anchored to specific textual cues (“emphatic tone”, refusal to allow argument).

NOTE: Build a character-trait vocabulary bank during revision. Strong candidates: aloof, gracious, calculating, magnanimous, intransigent, conciliatory, austere, indulgent, mercurial, stoic, vindictive, sycophantic.

B3 — Tone / Attitude Inference

Technique. The question asks for the writer’s (or a character’s) tone or attitude. Give a precise tone-word (one word or short phrase). Do not confuse tone with emotion.

Why this technique works. Tone is the writer’s stance towards the subject; attitude is the writer’s disposition towards a topic or person. Both are inferred from word choice, register, and rhetorical posture. The mark is for the precision of the tone-word: “sarcastic” is precise; “negative” is not.

1. Identify the line or comment the question points to.
2. Ask: is the writer praising, mocking, lamenting, defending, dismissing, warning?
3. Pick a single precise tone-word.
4. If asked to justify, point to the word or phrase that signals the tone.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The writer’s tone is _____, because _____.” (One precise tone-word + brief justification anchored to text.)

Worked Example B3 — Specimen Paper Q18(b)

Question: What is the writer’s tone when he describes Indominus rex as “the most accurate of them all”? [1]

Answer: The writer’s tone is ironic (or sarcastic). He calls a wholly fictional creature “the most accurate” precisely because, being invented, it cannot be measured against any scientific reality — so the claim mocks the filmmakers’ loose attitude towards accuracy.

Why this scores: A precise tone-word (ironic / sarcastic) is given, and the answer explains *why* the tone reads as ironic — by anchoring it to the absurdity of calling a fictional dinosaur “accurate”.

NOTE: Useful tone-word bank: *ironic, sarcastic, wry, indignant, reverent, dismissive, lamenting, admiring, cautionary, sceptical, affectionate, scathing, resigned, exasperated, nostalgic.*

B4 — State-of-Mind / Reaction Inference

Technique. The question quotes a phrase (often a physical description) and asks what it tells us about a character’s state of mind or reaction. Give a precise short-phrase answer.

Why this technique works. Physical descriptions in fiction are almost always external signals of internal states (“*rooted to the ground*” signals paralysis from shock; “*turning lazy circles in the sky*” signals a relaxed, drifting mind). The mark is for translating the physical detail into the corresponding mental state.

1. Identify the physical phrase the question quotes.
2. Ask: what internal state would normally produce this external behaviour?
3. Name the state in a precise word or short phrase.
4. Keep the answer short and sharp — one phrase is usually enough for one mark.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“[Character] is _____ — so _____ that he / she _____.” (Name the internal state; show how it produces the physical detail in the question.)

Worked Example B4 — past-year style

Question: What does the phrase “rooted to the ground” tell us about Delia’s reaction to her first sight of the lions? [1]

Answer: Delia is paralysed by shock and fear — she is so overwhelmed that she cannot move.

Why this scores: The physical immobility is correctly translated into the corresponding internal state (paralysis from shock / fear). The answer is short and precise.

B5 — Literary Device Effect (simile, metaphor, personification, hyperbole)

Technique. The question names a literary device (or quotes a clear example) and asks what it suggests. Identify the comparison being made, then explain what the comparison implies about the subject.

Why this technique works. You will not be asked to define the device — you are assumed to know what a simile or metaphor is. The mark is for showing that you can evaluate the *effect* of the comparison. A simile such as “like a giant bowl of icy porridge” tells you the water was thick, cold, and sluggish to move through — so the writer’s body movement was correspondingly constrained.

1. Identify the two things being compared (*the pool* ↔ *a bowl of icy porridge*).
2. Ask: what qualities does the second thing have? (*Thick, cold, viscous, hard to stir.*)
3. Apply those qualities to the subject. (*Therefore the water was thick, slow, and difficult to move through.*)
4. Tie the implication back to what the question specifically asked.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

"The [simile / metaphor / personification] compares _____ to _____, which suggests that _____. (Name the device, identify both halves of the comparison, transfer the qualities.)"

Worked Example B5 — Specimen Paper Q12

Question: The writer compares the pool to "a giant bowl of icy porridge". What does the simile suggest about the writer's ability to move? [1]

Answer: The simile suggests that the water had become so thick and semi-solid that the writer could only move through it slowly and with great difficulty, as though wading through a heavy, congealed substance.

Why this scores: The qualities of icy porridge (thick, viscous, semi-solid) are correctly transferred to the water, and the implication for movement (slow, difficult) is explicitly stated — which is what the question asked.

B6 — Language-Use / Stylistic Effect (with evidence)

Technique. The question asks how the writer's language creates a specific effect (*makes the storm seem like an aggressive person; emphasises leanness; raises tension*), and demands 2–3 supporting details. For each detail: quote it, then explain how it produces the named effect.

Why this technique works. The mark is split between identification (finding the right pieces of language) and analysis (explaining how each piece produces the effect). One without the other scores partially. The standard structure is: *quote* → "suggests" / "conveys" → *explanation tied to the named effect*.

1. Identify the named effect (e.g. "aggressive person").
2. Hunt the passage for verbs, adjectives, similes, personification, sound effects that produce that effect.
3. Pick the strongest 2 or 3 (matching the mark allocation).
4. For each: quote → "suggests" → short explanation.
5. Do not repeat the same explanation across two quotations.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

"The [verb / adjective / phrase] '_____' suggests _____, reinforcing the impression of _____. In addition, '_____' conveys _____, which further ... " (Repeat the quote-then-suggests structure for each mark; vary the verbs.)

Worked Example B6 — Specimen Paper Q10

Question: Explain how the language in Paragraph 5 makes the storm seem like an aggressive person. Support your answer with two details. [2]

Answer:

1. The verb "slapped" (in "the wind slapped against her face") suggests that the storm was striking her like a hostile person delivering a physical blow.
2. The phrase "shrieking down at her" personifies the wind as a furious assailant shouting in anger, reinforcing the sense that the storm was attacking her deliberately.

Why this scores: Two distinct quotations are given, each followed by a precise explanation tying the language to the "aggressive person" effect. No repetition.

B7 — Word-Choice / Vocabulary Inference

Technique. The question singles out one word or phrase (“*still*”; “*insidious*”; “*planted*”) and asks what it suggests or why the writer chose it. Define the word, then explain its implication in this context.

Why this technique works. This is a vocabulary-meets-comprehension question. The mark depends on (a) knowing what the word means and (b) explaining what it adds to the writer’s argument or scene. Do not repeat the word in your answer; show your understanding by paraphrasing what it conveys.

1. Define the named word in your head. What does it literally mean?
2. Ask: what does its use here add to the sentence? (Urgency? Stealth? Sarcasm? Hope?)
3. Write the answer without re-using the word.
4. If the word is in inverted commas in the text, consider whether the writer is being ironic.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“It suggests that _____, implying _____.” (Capture the implication of the word *without* re-using the word itself.)

Worked Example B7 — Specimen Paper Q2

Question: The advertisement states: “We still have a chance to make a big difference”. What does the word “still” suggest? [1]

Answer: It suggests that the situation has reached a critical stage but it is not yet too late — there remains a narrow window in which action can change the outcome for the better.

Why this scores: The word “still” is not repeated. The answer captures the precise implication (*near-too-late, but action remains possible*) by paraphrasing rather than restating.

B8 — Inverted-Comma / Punctuation Inference

Technique. The question asks why the writer puts inverted commas around a word, or uses a particular piece of punctuation (ellipsis, dash, question mark). Identify the rhetorical purpose — distance, irony, scepticism, doubt, emphasis — and explain it with reference to the text.

Why this technique works. Inverted commas around a word almost always signal that the writer is distancing themselves from it — using it ironically, sceptically, or in a sense that is not the standard one. The mark is for naming this distance correctly and showing what the writer’s real position is.

1. Locate the word or phrase in inverted commas.
2. Ask: does the writer believe this word literally? Or are they signalling irony, doubt, or someone else’s voice?
3. Name the rhetorical purpose (*ironic / sceptical / distancing / sarcastic*).
4. Briefly explain what the writer actually thinks.

SENTENCE TEMPLATE.

“The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being _____: although the word literally means _____, the writer actually thinks _____.” (Name the rhetorical purpose, then say what the writer truly means.)

Worked Example B8 — past-year style

Question: Why do you think the writer puts inverted commas around the word “planted”? [1]

Answer: The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being ironic or sceptical: the trees were not truly planted in the careful, nurturing sense the word usually implies, but were placed there as a token gesture, possibly without real concern for their survival.

Why this scores: The rhetorical purpose (irony / scepticism) is named, and the answer makes clear what the writer really thinks (that the planting was a token gesture, not a genuine act of care).

Quick Decision Tree — Which Category Is This Question?

Step 1 (apply SWIFT). Read the question. Does it contain any **Suggest** / **Why** / **Impression** / **Feeling** / **Tone** word? If yes → Cat B (use EIL). If no → Cat A (use FLIP).

Step 2. Confirm by checking for these specific signal phrases:

- “Give a detail / evidence / example / quotation” → Cat A.
- “In your own words” → Cat A (A3).
- “Identify the phrase / sentence / word” → Cat A (A2).
- “Explain how this claim is supported” → Cat A (A4).
- “Justify / how could the filmmakers justify” → Cat A (A8).
- Cartoon-head conversation → Cat A (A5).
- Flow-chart → Cat A (A7).
- “What is the contrast between...” → Cat A (A6).

Step 3. If none of those signals appear, look for inference signals:

- “Suggest / what does this suggest” → Cat B (B1 / B5).
- “Why do you think / what do you think” → Cat B (B1).
- “Tone” / “attitude” → Cat B (B3).
- “Impression of” / “what sort of person” → Cat B (B2).
- “State of mind” / “reaction” → Cat B (B4).
- “Simile / metaphor / personification” → Cat B (B5).
- “How does the language...” / “what effect...” → Cat B (B6).
- Question targets one word or inverted-comma word → Cat B (B7 / B8).

Step 4. Apply the technique for the matched question type. Use FLIP for any Cat A question and EIL for any Cat B question if unsure. Then plug your answer into the sentence template provided for that question type.

Common Errors to Avoid

- **Cat A error: lifting where paraphrase is demanded.** If “in your own words” appears, lifting scores zero.
- **Cat A error: paraphrasing where the literal lift is safest.** For pure detail-retrieval questions, change nothing.
- **Cat A error: Excess Denied.** Adding a wrong detail next to a correct one cancels the mark.
- **Cat B error: evidence without inference.** Quoting the line without saying what it implies is half an answer.
- **Cat B error: inference without evidence.** Asserting a feeling or trait without anchoring it to the text is unsupported.
- **Cat B error: vague tone-words.** “Negative” is not a tone. “Indignant”, “scathing”, “resigned” are tones.
- **Both categories: ignoring mark allocation.** Two marks = two points. Three marks = three pieces of evidence.

Final reminder. Every question in Sections B and C is one of the sixteen types above. If you cannot place a question in a type within ten seconds, you have misread it. Re-read the question slowly — the signal word is always there.